

Introduction: Pat Summitt's Contributions to Title IX and Gender Equality

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All of us know strong, successful women who have made us who we are today. Whether it was a relative, friend or mentor, women have been the backbone of society – and the workforce – long before they were officially recognized.

For me, one of those women was Pat Summitt. I've got to tell you, I met her for the first time in 1987. I was a young sports reporter on television and there weren't a lot of women that were doing it at that time. It was very challenging. I had so many conversations with Pat, and she was a beacon, a real beacon for me, a real mentor, a real friend. Just a short time later, I was at ESPN the worldwide leader in sports.

Pat wouldn't have considered herself a feminist – she considered herself a “subversive.” That is, someone immersed in a man's world at the time, who was slowly re-defining the perception of women in her field by her actions. As a woman in a male-dominated industry, she smashed the glass ceiling over and over again, paving the way for other women to succeed.

Pat once said, “Here's how I'm going to beat you. I'm going to outwork you. That's all there is to it.” That's so Pat. She was the first female coach to be on the cover of *Sports Illustrated* in 1998. She was the first female coach to negotiate a salary of \$1 million and insist that she be paid equally with the other male coaches in her profession.

Pat was also the first person to be an Olympic winner both as a player *and* a coach. She was “Coach of the 20th Century,” in addition to “NCAA Coach of the Year” seven times. In 2012, she was awarded the Presidential Medal of Freedom, the country's highest civilian honor, alongside other recipients such as Bill and Melinda Gates, John Glenn, and Stephen Hawking.

The road to gender equality in the workplace hasn't been an easy one. There are still many obstacles to women in leadership and making the workplace a more level playing field for their bright, talented contributions.

In this course, you'll learn more about how we all got here, including some of the specific roadblocks for women in leadership. You'll learn about microaggressions and how they can be damaging – to any gender – and about some of the specific strengths of female leaders.

You'll learn how to "own your game" and be a master of your own destiny, specifically as it relates to communication, key conversations and negotiation.

In Pat's own words, "Belief in yourself is what happens when you *know* you've done the thing things that entitle you to success."

Pat believed women everywhere could be – and *already were* leaders.

And you can be too.